One day, Narendra and I were sitting poring over our planning board. It was a simple thermocol sheet with the map of the AOR pasted on it with coloured pins showing the days of the various intercepts and their locations, with bits of string joining the pins to show the movement pattern. All very basic, no computer-generated programs or AI or anything. The civil phone rang; the exchange operator said that there was a civilian wanting to speak to me, who said, '*CO Sahib mere se zarur baat karenge*.' When I asked for the name of this civilian caller, the operator said it was someone called Samra. I couldn't believe my ears. When we got through, Samra said he wanted a face-to-face meeting and that I should come alone to such and such place. I had put the call on speaker and Narendra was listening in. I told Samra that I would call back on his number, displayed on the caller ID, a new thing those days. It could be a trap said Narendra, there's no way you can go alone. Better he should come to the camp gate. We conferred for a few minutes before calling back and making this offer.

'How do I know you won't kill me on sight?' countered Samra.

This discussion went on for some time. Finally, I told him that it was he who had rung up offering to surrender; the choice was his. He could get another person along as a witness to guarantee his safety.

The main gate of the camp had a visitors' room where civilians would come for some of their personal work or even for the odd purchase from the wet canteen run by the civilian contractor. This was a regular practice as it also gave a cover to those locals wanting to come to the camp with some information on terrorist activities. We asked Samra to merge with this stream of people and come the next day, and to ask for the 2iC on reaching the gate. There was an air of suppressed

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